



TinkerTaps

READ THIS AND RELAX

A TINKERTAPS GUIDE

Not All Screen Time Is *Bad*

A calm, guilt-free guide to toddler screens. What actually matters, what does not, and how to tell the difference in about ten seconds.

AGES 1 TO 4

GUILT FREE

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BUILT IN NASHVILLE

Not All Screen Time Is Bad

Hey

If you are reading this, there is a decent chance you handed your kid a tablet in the last week and then felt weird about it.

Been there. Am there. I have two kids and I build toddler apps for a living, which means I have read more about this than any reasonable person should, and I still had a moment last month at a restaurant where I handed over my phone and thought "well, I am the screen time guy, this is going great."

So let's take the temperature down. Here's the thing that took me way too long to figure out: **screen time is not one thing**. Twenty minutes of a kid tapping shapes and naming colors with you sitting next to them is not the same activity as ninety minutes of autoplay videos with flashing transitions every four seconds. Same clock, completely different experience for their brain.

Almost every guilt spiral about screens comes from measuring the wrong thing. We count minutes because minutes are easy to count. What actually matters is harder to measure and way more useful to know.

This guide is what I wish someone had handed me. No lecturing, no fear, no "unplug your child and move to a cabin." Just the stuff that turned out to be true.

What the guidance actually says

You have probably heard "no screens before two" and "one hour a day for ages two to five." Those numbers come from the American Academy of Pediatrics, and they are reasonable starting points.

Here's the part that got left out of the headline, though. The same guidance emphasizes **what** kids watch and **who is with them**, not just how long. It specifically calls out that video chatting with grandma is fine at any age, and it recommends watching together and talking about what you see rather than handing the device over and walking away.

In other words, the official advice has always been more nuanced than the number everybody remembers.

The other thing worth knowing: a lot of research on this topic measures screen time as one giant blob, mostly passive video, because that is what is easiest to study. When researchers separate the types, the picture changes. Passive video on autoplay looks quite different from an app a kid is actively using, which looks different again from a video call with family. Studies that look at what children are actually doing tend to find that content and context matter as much as duration.

So the honest summary is this: **the hour guideline is a fine default. The quality of what is on the screen and whether you are part of it matter at least as much.**

And this next part matters more than any of it: nothing in this guide is medical advice. Your pediatrician knows your kid. If you have a real concern about development, speech, sleep, or behavior, that is the conversation to have, and it is a good conversation to have early rather than late.

The three questions that replace counting minutes

Instead of tracking a timer, ask three things. It takes about ten seconds and it tells you more than the clock does.

▪ 1. Is my kid doing something, or having something done to them?

This is the big one.

Doing something looks like: tapping and getting a response, choosing what happens next, naming things out loud, singing, copying a movement, solving something, building something, laughing at something they caused.

Having something done to them looks like: watching autoplay, scrolling a feed, sitting through fast cuts and loud transitions with no place to participate, twenty minutes gone with no decision made.

Neither one is evil. But if you are going to make one of them the everyday default, make it the first one.

▪ 2. Am I anywhere near this?

You do not have to sit there for every minute. Nobody is doing that and anyone who says they are is not making dinner.

But when you can, being nearby changes the activity completely. Narrating counts. "Oh, you found the blue one" is you doing language development while unloading the dishwasher. Kids learn more from screens when an adult is around to connect it to real life, and that effect is consistently one of the strongest findings in this whole area.

Being in the room and occasionally saying words is a completely legitimate version of "co-viewing." You do not need to be enthralled.

▪ 3. How is the landing?

Watch what happens in the ten minutes after the screen goes away.

A good landing: they wander off and start playing with something else. Maybe a little grumbling. Life continues.

A rough landing: total meltdown, cannot re-engage with anything, asks for it constantly for an hour, seems wired or wrung out.

The landing tells you almost everything about whether that particular app or show is working for your particular kid. Some content is engineered to make the landing hard, because a hard landing means more usage, and more usage is the business model. You do not need a study to tell you that. You have eyes and you have a two year old.

If the landing is consistently rough, change the content before you change the clock. It is usually the content.

How to spot a good toddler app in about ten seconds

Open it yourself before you hand it over. Ten seconds is genuinely enough.

▪ Green flags

- **It waits for the kid.** Nothing happens until they do something. Good toddler apps are patient.
- **One idea per screen.** Not a carnival.
- **The pace is slow.** Toddlers process slower than the adults who make apps, and good apps account for that.
- **Sounds are gentle and mean something.** A sound should be feedback, not a firework.
- **There is a natural stopping point.** An end. A finish. Something you can point at and say "we did it, all done."
- **You can turn the music down or off** without hunting through five menus.
- **Parent settings are behind an adult gate** and are actually parent settings, not a store.
- **No leaderboard, no streak, no daily reward.** Those are engagement mechanics designed for adults with impulse control problems. Your three year old does not need a streak.

▪ Red flags

- **Autoplay to the next thing.** The single worst feature in kids' media. If it exists, find the setting and kill it.
- **Ads.** Especially the ones that look like part of the game. Toddlers cannot tell the difference. That is precisely why they are there.
- **Buy buttons a kid could hit.** You will find out about this on a Tuesday.
- **Timers, pressure, fail states.** Two year olds do not need to be under the clock.
- **Flashing transitions every few seconds.** If it makes you feel jumpy, it is doing more of that to them.
- **No end.** Infinite content is a design decision, and it is not a decision made with your kid in mind.
- **It brags about time spent.** Read that sentence again. Whose goal is that?

The ten second test: open the app, count how long before something happens that you did not ask for. If it is under five seconds, it is not built for a toddler. It is built for a metric.

What to actually do instead of counting

▪ Anchor screens to a slot, not a stopwatch

"After lunch" is a much better rule than "45 minutes." Kids understand slots. They fight timers.

A slot is predictable, and predictable is the thing that stops the constant asking. When there is no rule, every moment is a negotiation. When the rule is "we do TinkerTaps after lunch," the answer to "can I have the tablet" is just "after lunch," and it is the same answer every time, and eventually they stop asking.

Slots that tend to work:

- After lunch, before nap
- The witching hour while dinner is being made, which is when most of us are handing over a device anyway

- Long car rides, waiting rooms, the flight
- The quiet part of Saturday morning while you are trying to be a person who has coffee

▪ Give the ending a shape

Most tablet meltdowns are not about the tablet. They are about a thing ending abruptly with no warning. Adults hate that too, we just have more practice.

What works:

1. **A warning.** "Two more, then all done." Then keep your word, every time, even when it is inconvenient.
2. **An ending they can see.** Finish the puzzle, finish the song, get to the end of the thing. Ending mid-activity is a fight you have chosen to have.
3. **Something next.** "All done, come help me with the carrots." An empty hand right after a screen is a hand looking for trouble. Give it a job.
4. **Let them turn it off.** Handing them the power button turns being done into something they did, and it works far more often than it should.

▪ The thing to be way more careful about

If you take one hard rule out of this whole guide: **screens close to bedtime are a different animal.** Sleep is where a lot of the real, measurable harm shows up, and it is the thing that makes everything else about the next day harder. Try for a real gap before bed, an hour if you can manage it. Keep devices out of the bedroom.

Everybody is more flexible about the afternoon than the evening for a reason.

What screens are genuinely good at

This is the part that gets left out of most articles, so let's say it plainly. There are things a screen does well.

- **Video calls with people who are far away.** This one is not a compromise, it is a genuine good. Grandparents get a relationship they would not otherwise have.
- **A quiet activity when quiet is required.** Waiting rooms, flights, the DMV, a funeral, the appointment where you need to actually hear the doctor. Your kid being calm in public is not a moral failure.
- **A survivable witching hour.** Somebody has to cook dinner. That somebody is you.
- **Naming and language practice.** Toddler apps that ask a kid to find, name, match, and repeat are doing real language work, especially when you are nearby saying the words too.
- **Cause and effect.** Tap, thing happens. That is genuine learning and it is delightful at that age.
- **Fifteen minutes so you can be a person.** A parent who got a shower is better at parenting than a parent who did not. That is the whole justification and it is enough.

You are allowed to use a tool. That is what it is.

The guilt part

Here's the thing nobody tells you. The guilt is doing more damage to your household than the twenty minutes of tapping.

When you feel bad about it, you get inconsistent. You allow it, then you feel guilty, then you crack down hard, then you are exhausted and you allow more, and the rules change every day. Kids read inconsistency like a weather report and they push exactly where the pressure is lowest. Now you have a negotiation running all day long.

Pick a rule you can actually keep. Keep it calmly. That is worth more than a stricter rule you break on Thursdays.

And the parents I know who worry the most about screen time are, without exception, the ones doing the best job. Worried parents are engaged parents. The fact that you read a guide about this is the evidence. You are fine.

The one-page version, stick it on the fridge

Instead of counting minutes, ask:

1. Are they doing something, or having something done to them?
2. Am I anywhere nearby?
3. How is the landing when it ends?

Good app in ten seconds: waits for the kid, one idea per screen, slow pace, gentle sounds, has an ending, no ads, no autoplay, no streaks.

Bad app in ten seconds: something happens before they touch it, ads, autoplay, flashing, infinite, brags about time spent.

Three habits that fix almost everything:

- Anchor it to a slot, not a stopwatch
- Warn, finish, and hand them something to do next
- Protect the hour before bed, seriously, that is the one

And the rule under all of them: pick something you can keep, keep it calmly, and stop apologizing to yourself about it.

About TinkerTaps

I build TinkerTaps because I wanted the thing described in this guide to exist for my own kids. Quiet sensory activities for toddlers. Slow pace, one idea per screen, gentle sounds, a clear ending. No ads. No autoplay. No streaks, no leaderboards, nothing engineered to make the landing hard.

It will not fry their brain, and it will not fry yours either, which honestly was a design goal.

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This guide is one dad's take plus a lot of reading, not medical advice. Your pediatrician knows your kid and I do not. If something feels off with sleep, speech, or behavior, ask them early. That is what they are there for.